

When Sanctions Work: The cases of Libya, North Korea and Russia

Abstract

Sanctions are usually judged against an unrealistic standard: whether they force a target state to fully reverse course. Indeed, sanctions work under specific conditions i.e. the target's degree of interdependence with the sender, its domestic political context, and the sender's own need to satisfy domestic audiences. Testing this framework against Libya, North Korea and Russia, the analysis finds that sanctions succeeded in constraining Libya's nuclear programme by exploiting its economic dependence, but failed to compel North Korea or Russia, whose authoritarian structures let them shift costs away from ruling elites. Even where they fail to secure compliance, however, sanctions consistently succeed in performing a symbolic function that sustains their use over time.

Introduction

There is a widespread misconception that views sanctions as coercive tools that prompts a need to reframe the lens through which they are analysed. Sanctions should be understood as tools with limited capacity that do “work” under specific conditions: the degree of interdependence with the sender, the political context in the target country and their impact on the sender’s audience.

To explore this hypothesis, the analysis will first treat these conditions as independent variables, studying the theory behind them and testing them against the effectiveness of sanctions, the dependent variable. Afterwards, the following sections will individually test the hypothesis against three case studies: US and UN sanctions imposed on the Gaddafi regime in Libya, US sanctions on North Korea and EU sanctions on Russia. These case studies vary across bilateral and multilateral sanctions but focus on autocratic regimes and coercive goals.

Theoretical considerations: sanctions beyond coercion

Firstly, the dependent variable requires redefinition. Their role goes beyond their coercive functions that have created unrealistic benchmarks on which to judge effectiveness. The most relevant example of this is Robert A. Pape's view that sanctions only work in 5 out of 115 of the cases (Pape 1997, 93). For this reason, a thorough analysis needs to view them as tools of statecraft that "seek to limit the state's access to economic resources or cultural and social engagement, and limit movements of its nationals" (Brooks 2010, 6). Therefore, it is crucial to consider their role in signaling, weakening the target country's economic and military capabilities, and addressing domestic audiences. This allows the analysis to include the contribution of sanctions to broader strategies, creating a more realistic benchmark on which to judge their effectiveness.

Secondly, to create a basis through which to analyse the independent variables, one needs to analyse the mechanisms through which they influence the effectiveness of sanctions.

On the one hand, the degree of interdependence between the target country and the sender, and the political context in the target country both determine political costs of defiance, a central mechanism that creates the necessary conditions for sanctions to be effective. Political costs of defiance can be defined as domestic pressures, from the population or elites, faced by a government as a result of external pressures, in this case sanctions, that can induce them into compliance. Interdependence determines how dependent the target country is on the sender and how significant the relationship with the sender is (Drezner 1999; Silva and Selden 2019), thus conditioning the target country into complying with the sender through increasing external vulnerability. The political context of a country, particularly connected to its regime type, determines the response of the target government, their ability to resist their impact and the degree to which audiences will pressure change. Particularly, oppressive regimes tend to be stronger against sanctions as they shift their burden from elites onto the population (Escribà-

Folch and Wright 2010, 355) and will create a rally-around-the-flag-effect against the sender, nullifying any vulnerabilities and internal pressures that sanctions could have created and leading to their ineffectiveness.

On the other hand, sanctions persist over time in spite of failures to bring change or achieving goals thanks to their impact on the sender's domestic audiences. They address "public demands for action" (Altiparmak and Thies 2025, 124), thus allowing the sender to deal with domestic pressures. This introduces the symbolic role of sanctions, which makes them a goal onto themselves (Altiparmak and Thies 2025), at least to a certain extent.

The effectiveness of multilateral sanctions in Libya

Following the Lockerbie bombing, the US and the UN imposed sanctions on Libya (Hovi et al. 2005, 489); nevertheless, the US had long term interest in disarming Libya of nuclear weapons (Cirincione et al. 2005, 318). They achieved this objective when the Gaddafi regime announced they would be abandoning the programme in 2003 (Cirincione et al. 2005, 315). These sanctions worked because they were included in a wider coercive diplomatic effort (Jentleson and Whytock 2005, 57-79) that combined force, i.e. sanctions and military action, and diplomacy effectively (Cirincione et al. 2005, 319). While secret negotiations between Libya, the UK and the US (Jentleson and Whytock 2005, 50) led to achieving the overall goal, it was sanctions that weakened the Libyan economy and created diplomatic leverage. Indeed, the overall costs have been estimated to be around \$26.5 billion, slowing down the economy (Bahgat 2005, 6) and complicating the development of a nuclear programme over time (Cirincione et al. 2005, 317-8 and 324). Therefore, this showcases how sanctions alone are insufficient, as their success is contingent on other tools of statecraft, reinforcing the idea that sanctions enable wider efforts rather than independently achieving economic goals.

As autocracies do to counter sanctions, Gaddafi's regime attempted to create a rally-around-the flag effect by "appropriating the symbols and norms of liberal internationalism" (Hurd 2005, 495). Nevertheless, these efforts were in vain as the regime was weakened by its dependence on the oil exports, which were sanctioned since 1993 (Bahgat 2005, 7). Indeed, most Libyan oil was exported to Europe (Bahgat 2005, 6), which caused a large hit after sanctions were applied and undermined the regime's capacity to internalise profits and thus redistribute rents towards elites, as they had been doing to secure support (Altunışic 1996, 77-9). This directly impacted core internal support and made the regime more vulnerable. Altogether, the high degree of interdependence of the country with oil importers, did not allow the regime to exploit the mechanisms of autocracies that allow them to bypass the domestic pressures created by sanctions, like rally-around-the-flag effects, making political costs of defiance too high.

In terms of their symbolic role, sanctions gained significance as nuclear proliferation became a salient issue due to its relationship with terrorism (Bahgat 2005, 4 and 5) during the War on Terror, and particularly after the Iraq War began in 2003. This legitimised sanctions in sender states, as exemplified by Bush claiming credit for Libya's disarmament (Bruce St John 2004, 386) and European policies like the EU Strategy against Proliferation of WMD (Bahgat 2005, 5). These explicit diplomatic efforts illustrate the importance of narrative at the time, and the focus that the senders had on the perception of audiences, making the leverage created by sanctions even more relevant in wider strategic efforts as a bargaining tool.

Overall, sanctions worked in Libya because all key variables aligned. This case study showcases the interaction between interdependence and the political context, as sanctions did not allow the Gaddafi regime to shift costs onto the population by targeting oil exports. These

pressures made the costs of defying the US and the UN too high and forced the country to surrender its nuclear programme. Moreover, the relation between anti-terrorist and non-proliferation efforts made sanctions relevant amongst domestic audiences during the War on Terror, making the previous variables increasingly significant by satisfying internal demands for action, which made the role of sanctions within diplomatic efforts more significant and effective.

The failure of long-term US sanctions in North Korea

The coercive goal of US sanctions on North Korea, i.e. compellence towards non-proliferation, has proven overly ambitious given its long-term ineffectiveness. Moreover, the integration of these tools into larger strategic efforts beyond threats (Kim and Martin-Hermosillo 2013, 102) has been inconsistent, reinforcing their ineffectiveness. The temporary success of diplomatic efforts which led to the dismantling of the Yongbyon nuclear processing plant in 2007 (Shin et al 2009, 876) illustrates what a consistent strategy could have looked like. To an extent, these coercive sanctions failed because of overambition and ineffective integration with other tools.

Focusing on the independent variables, North Korea is isolated from the Western world, thus interdependence with the sender is low. Moreover, the failure of other countries in the UN to comply to multilateral sanctions further damaged this, as North Korea found substitutes like China (Myong-Hyun 2020), who imports its luxury goods and exports fuel and aid (Kim and Martin-Hermosillo 2013, 101 and 106) to weaken the pressures of sanctions. Therefore, external pressures have failed to create costs of defiance due to the weak relation of North Korea with sanctioning countries, especially the US, has kept costs of defiance low.

Political context has also contributed to making sanctions ineffective. Indeed, North Korea is strongly autocratic, supported by a lack of internal opposition strengthened by its isolation. Furthermore, the centrally planned North Korean economy allows for resources to be reallocated, and costs to be shifted onto the population (Kim and Martin-Hermosillo 2013, 106). This is exemplified by the severe health crisis caused by sanctions, which has directly hit the population and failed to sway the regime into complying to de-proliferation demands (Shin et al 2009, 876). Unlike the Libyan case, this is an example of how an oppressive regime can effectively counter sanctions by exploiting the characteristics of an autocracy, thus avoiding internal pressures from the population.

In spite of their failure, these sanctions have persisted due to their symbolic role. Indeed, sanctions have been consistently strengthened as a response to frequent nuclear weapon tests that have been taking place since 2006 (Kim and Martin-Hermosillo 2013, 100 and 102). This direct defiance has transformed their goal into attempts of retribution, which aim at punishing the target (Hufbauer and Jung 2020, 9) and appeasing domestic demands. Nevertheless, sanctions have failed to effectively perform their symbolic function due to the persistent defiance, reinforcing domestic pressures and forcing sanctions to persist over time.

Overall, this case is an example of sanctions not working when all proposed variables do not create the right conditions. They failed to create political costs of defiance due to North Korea's isolation from the West, supported by Chinese support, and by the strength of the North Korean regime. Furthermore, the symbolic role of sanctions has also failed, due to constant provocations in the form of nuclear weapons tests, which have reinforced domestic pressures but led to their persistence.

The ambiguous effectiveness of EU sanction on Russia

The EU has been imposing sanctions on Russia as a response to the 2014 and 2022 invasions, the latter which was considered particularly harsh (Giumelli 2024, 212). These sanctions have aimed at contributing to efforts towards coercing Russia from invading Ukraine but have failed. This has showcased failure in the nature of their goal, due to overambition, even when applied into a wider diplomatic effort (Giumelli 2024, 222). This long-term failure and overambition showcases similarities with the North Korean case.

Interdependence should increase the effectiveness of sanctions by creating vulnerability, as showcased by the Libyan case, yet the Russian case showcases how this mechanism can be undermined. Indeed, Russia used to be a major exporter of energy, particularly to the EU, receiving around half of Russia's oil exports before the invasion in 2022 (Feveile Adolfsen et al. 2023) in spite of the already present long-term sanctions. Nevertheless, the country has been able to undermine this dependence by finding substitutes, i.e. China and India who have increased their imports of crude oil largely (Fouad 2024, 264-6) and have OPEC+ support Russian oil exports to keep prices high (Fouad 2024, 267). This has diluted European leverage by preventing economic pressures from translating into political costs for the regime, something the Libyan regime failed to do.

When considering the political context, similar to the North Korean case, the Russian regime has remained strong. Indeed, Russian oligarchs have become more dependent on the government because of an increased centralisation of the economy, leading them to rally-around-the-flag-effect towards Putin (Fenton and Kolyandr 2025, 8). Nevertheless, there has been certain opposition requiring oppressive measures and propaganda as a counter (Giumelli 2024, 224), but it has not been strong enough to compel the Russian government into de-

escalation. Sanctions have effectively weakened the Russian economy and made military costs of the conflict particularly harsh (Demarais 2022), making military achievements harder. However, once again, such negative effect has been countered, at least temporarily, by the shift towards wartime economy (Fenton and Kolyandr 2025). Therefore, despite sanctions creating internal pressures on the Russian regime, these have been countered through the exploitation of autocratic character of the regime, i.e. insulating elites and relocating resources, thus failing to increase political costs once again.

By contrast, the symbolic role of sanctions has been interestingly effective. As Paul M. Silva and Zachary Selden argue, the imposition of sanctions from European countries has largely been based on proximity and relations to Russia (Silva and Selden 2018, 230), therefore these sanctions have been imposed to address domestic and regional pressures for action. As Francesco Giumelli similarly argues “resorting to sanctions carries a meaning in itself” (Giumelli 2024, 217), where these sanctions fulfil a signalling role that creates the basis for long term application. Indeed, considering their imposition despite long term failures, their symbolic role has had a large role in leading countries to continue using this tool. An example of their effectiveness amongst domestic audiences has been the withdrawal of firms from Russia, prompted by these economic actions in the country which has created pressures to relocate and cut ties (Wyrebkowski 2025, 9), thus showcasing the normative role.

Overall, sanctions on Russia worked to an extent, but their impact has not been large enough to induce compellence. Sanctions have not yet made political costs of defiance high enough as pressures have been undermined by the strength of the regime and the diversion of exports. Nevertheless, they have been largely effective in their symbolic role as they have been able to address internal pressures and signalled action.

Conclusion

Sanctions do work under specific conditions, created by the proposed independent variables, and when their limited capacity is understood and correctly utilised beyond misconceptions of the nature of their role.

When reviewing the dependent variable in this study, its effectiveness has relied largely on its inclusion into wider strategic contexts, particularly alongside diplomacy. This was exemplified by the Libyan case and its limited wins in the North Korean case. All examples, nevertheless, have proven the issues with overvaluing the capacity of sanctions by showcasing the significance in strengthening the strategic environment rather than coercion. Their limited use has been shown to enhance effectiveness, as exemplified by their effectiveness in the Libyan case by weakening the economy or the Russian case by signalling firms to withdraw from Russia, while overambitious coercive goals have led to ineffectiveness, as demonstrated by North Korea and Russia.

Focusing on the independent variables, both the interdependence with the sender and the political context in the target country have proven to be particularly significant because they are the basis of the political costs of defiance that create the conditions for sanctions to work. The effectiveness of Libyan sanctions is owed to their interaction creating internal pressures that forced the regime to comply. Differently, the Russian and North Korean case studies are a long-term example of autocratic regimes exploiting their characteristics to shift costs away from key supporters and their ability to bypass interdependence, thus avoiding internal pressures that would prompt them to comply with sender demands. Finally, all of these

examples showcase how sanctions have a significant symbolic role in addressing domestic pressures for action, which pushes for persistence in their use regardless of effectiveness.

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